

1 **HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES - FLOOR VERSION**

2 STATE OF OKLAHOMA

3 2nd Session of the 60th Legislature (2026)

4 COMMITTEE SUBSTITUTE
5 FOR
6 HOUSE BILL NO. 3710

By: Caldwell (Chad) of the
House

and

Pugh of the Senate

9 COMMITTEE SUBSTITUTE

10 An Act relating to education; amending 70 O.S. 2021,
11 Section 2403, as amended by Section 3, Chapter 482,
12 O.S.L. 2025 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025, Section 2403), which
13 relates to eligibility requirements for the Oklahoma
14 Rising Scholars Award Program; authorizing the State
15 Regents to establish cohort-based award schedules;
16 permitting cohort-based award schedule amounts and
17 structure to vary by academic year; and providing an
18 effective date.

16 BE IT ENACTED BY THE PEOPLE OF THE STATE OF OKLAHOMA:

17 SECTION 1. AMENDATORY 70 O.S. 2021, Section 2403, as
18 amended by Section 3, Chapter 482, O.S.L. 2025 (70 O.S. Supp. 2025,
19 Section 2403), is amended to read as follows:

20 Section 2403. A. No person shall be eligible to participate in
21 the Oklahoma Rising Scholars Award Program unless the person:

22 1. Has complied with all of the rules promulgated by the
23 Oklahoma State Regents for Higher Education pursuant to the
24 provisions of the Oklahoma Rising Scholars Award Act, Section 2401

1 et seq. of this title, for the award, regulation, and administration
2 of scholarships; and

3 2. Qualifies as one of the following:

- 4 a. an Individual Applicant Qualified Student, which shall
5 mean a student who is a resident of the State of
6 Oklahoma whose American College Testing Program score
7 or whose Scholastic Aptitude Test score falls within
8 the 99.5 to 100.0 percentile levels as administered in
9 the State of Oklahoma and whose grade point average
10 and/or class rank is exceptional, as determined by the
11 State Regents,
- 12 b. a Presidential Scholar, which shall mean a student
13 selected by the Commission on Presidential Scholars
14 administered by the United States Department of
15 Education,
- 16 c. a National Merit Scholar, which shall mean a student
17 designated as a National Merit Scholar by the National
18 Merit Scholarship Corporation,
- 19 d. a National Merit Finalist, which shall mean a student
20 designated as a National Merit Finalist by the
21 National Merit Scholarship Corporation, or
- 22 e. after October 1, 1999, an Institutional Nominee, which
23 shall mean a student nominated by an institution in
24 The Oklahoma State System of Higher Education:

1 (1) whose American College Testing Program or
2 Scholastic Aptitude Test score falls within the
3 95.0 to 99.49 percentile levels, or
4 (2) who shows exceptional academic achievement as
5 evidenced by factors, including, but not limited
6 to, grade point average, class rank, national
7 awards, scholastic achievements, honors, and who
8 shows exceptional promise based on documentation
9 that may include, but not be limited to, teacher
10 recommendations, extracurricular activities, and
11 evidence of overcoming economic and social
12 obstacles as determined by the State Regents.
13 The State Regents shall ensure that standards of
14 high academic ability are documented.
15 Scholarship awards to Institutional Nominees
16 shall become effective when appropriate
17 documentation is verified by the State Regents.

18 B. No person shall be eligible to receive a scholarship
19 pursuant to the provisions of the Oklahoma Rising Scholars Award
20 Program unless the person is enrolled as a full-time student at a
21 public or private accredited institution of higher education in
22 Oklahoma.

23 C. For a student who qualifies pursuant to subparagraphs a
24 through d of paragraph 2 of subsection A of this section and subject

1 to the availability of funds, the Oklahoma Rising Scholars Award
2 Program shall provide a scholarship in an amount not to exceed the
3 costs of all enrollment fees, tuition and other fees, room and
4 board, and all required textbooks or materials for up to five (5)
5 years of undergraduate and/or graduate study at an accredited public
6 or private institution of higher education in Oklahoma. The State
7 Regents may establish separate scholarship award levels for each
8 qualifying category.

9 1. If the student is attending an institution within The
10 Oklahoma State System of Higher Education, the total funding for the
11 scholarship provided in this subsection, exclusive of any
12 internships, shall not exceed the costs for items specified in this
13 subsection at the institution attended as determined annually by the
14 Oklahoma State Regents for Higher Education.

15 2. If the student is attending a private institution of higher
16 education, the total funding for the scholarship provided in this
17 subsection, exclusive of any internships, shall not exceed the costs
18 for items specified in this subsection at an institution of The
19 Oklahoma State System of Higher Education of comparable type which
20 has the highest general enrollment fees of its type of institution
21 in The Oklahoma State System of Higher Education as determined
22 annually by the Oklahoma State Regents for Higher Education.

23 D. For a student who qualifies pursuant to subparagraph e of
24 paragraph 2 of subsection A of this section and subject to the

1 availability of funds, the Oklahoma Rising Scholars Award Program
2 shall provide a scholarship in an amount not to exceed the average
3 costs of all enrollment fees and other fees, room and board, and all
4 required textbooks or materials for up to five (5) years of
5 undergraduate and/or graduate study at an accredited public or
6 private institution of higher education in Oklahoma. The State
7 Regents may establish separate scholarship award levels for each
8 qualifying category.

9 1. If the student is attending an institution within The
10 Oklahoma State System of Higher Education, the institution shall
11 provide a tuition waiver not to exceed the average cost of tuition.
12 The total funding for the scholarship and waiver provided for
13 students attending an institution within The Oklahoma State System
14 of Higher Education as provided in this subsection, exclusive of any
15 internships, shall not exceed the costs for items specified in this
16 subsection at the institution attended as determined annually by the
17 Oklahoma State Regents for Higher Education.

18 2. If the student is attending a private institution of higher
19 education in Oklahoma, the scholarship shall include an amount not
20 to exceed the average cost of tuition. The total funding for
21 scholarships for students attending a private institution as
22 provided in this subsection, exclusive of any internships, shall not
23 exceed the costs for items specified in this subsection at an
24 institution within The Oklahoma State System of Higher Education of

1 comparable type which has the highest general enrollment fees of its
2 type of institution in The Oklahoma State System of Higher Education
3 as determined annually by the Oklahoma State Regents for Higher
4 Education.

5 E. If a person identifies himself or herself as a student with
6 a disability and requests consideration for a scholarship under the
7 Oklahoma Rising Scholars Award Program by means other than standard
8 testing procedures, the State Regents shall determine what means of
9 assessment are appropriate and upon the basis of said assessment
10 results, determine what level of award, if any, shall be made.

11 F. The State Regents may establish cohort-based award schedules
12 for the Oklahoma Rising Scholars Award Program. The cohort-based
13 award schedule amount and structure of scholarship funding
14 applicable to a recipient may vary by the academic year in which the
15 recipient is first awarded under the Oklahoma Rising Scholars Award
16 Act.

17 SECTION 2. This act shall become effective November 1, 2026.

18
19 COMMITTEE REPORT BY: COMMITTEE ON APPROPRIATIONS AND BUDGET, dated
20 03/05/2026 - DO PASS, As Amended and Coauthored.